

TRIAL BY TARMAC

Goa's airport-side circuit becomes the **latest stop** in Indian Racing Festival's street round.

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In a state more associated with beaches and holiday itineraries, motorsport isn't usually part of the schedule.

But on a February weekend in Goa, a stretch of road outside the Manohar International Airport hosted a round of the Indian Racing Festival (IRF), a franchise-based single-seater racing platform that also conducts a gender-neutral championship.

The temporary 12-turn, 2.064-kilometre circuit, cut into the red terrain, took shape under clear skies and persistent heat, with lap times consistently clocked under a minute.

The round was run using Formula 4 cars, one of the two championships

under the IRF umbrella, alongside the Indian Racing League (IRL).

The race marked the series' second street event after its earlier outing in Chennai, which drew attention for both its under-the-lights action and organisational hurdles. In comparison, Goa ran more smoothly, suggesting lessons had been learned.

Grandstands, paddock zones and fan enclosures created a compact but efficient venue.

Racing unfolded alongside everyday movement — traffic on nearby roads and aircraft approaching in the distance.

Curious locals and a 'home' element

Attendance at the event reflected the timing and location. While hospitality and paddock areas stayed active, the general stands thinned during peak

heat. Sunday, though, saw a noticeable rise, with locals lining the hillsides for a view of the track action.

"People in Goa love vehicles. A lot of bikers come here, and many new vehicles are launched here. It attracts a lot of people. Four-wheeler racing is here for the first time, and we are excited to watch," one spectator said.

A home team presence added to that interest. Goa Aces JA Racing had strong local backing, and race wins only amplified it. Following a three-race format — two on Saturday and a feature race on Sunday — Goa's home team triumphed in two of the three events to mark a successful weekend.

Raoul Hyman, an IRL regular driving for Goa Aces JA Racing for another season, became the first winner at the venue. He followed it up with a brilliant victory in the feature race, which featured a relay

